

Iron Man — Izzet Artifact Voltron

Tony Stark // The Invincible Iron Man · Bracket 3 (3.5 with Aggravated Assault) · 3/3 Game Changers · 100 cards

Lands 37	Equipment 15	Artifacts 41	Sources U23 / R22	Game Changers 3/3
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COMMANDER (1)

1 Tony Stark 2

LANDS (37)

- 1 Academy Ruins
- 1 Ancient Tomb
- 1 Archway of Innovation
- 1 Cascade Bluffs
- 1 Command Tower
- 1 Darksteel Citadel
- 1 Fomori Vault
- 1 Great Furnace
- 1 Inventors' Fair
- 3 Island
- 6 Mountain
- 1 Otawara, Soaring City
- 1 Riverpyre Verge
- 1 Scalding Tarn
- 1 Scorched Geyser
- 1 Seat of the Synod
- 1 Shivan Reef
- 1 Silverbluff Bridge
- 1 Steam Vents
- 1 Stormcarved Coast
- 1 Sulfur Falls
- 1 The Mycosynth Gardens
- 1 Thundering Falls
- 1 Training Center
- 1 Treasure Vault
- 1 Turbulent Springs
- 1 Urza's Saga
- 1 Uthros, Titanic Godcore
- 1 Volcanic Island
- 1 Sink into Stupor

RAMP / MANA ROCKS (8)

- 1 Sol Ring
- 1 Arcane Signet
- 1 Mind Stone
- 1 Talisman of Creativity
- 1 Thought Vessel
- 1 Cursed Mirror
- 1 Thran Dynamo
- 1 Arc Reactor

CARD DRAW (7)

- 1 Insight Engine
- 1 Armor Wars
- 1 Big Score
- 1 One with the Machine
- 1 The One Ring
- 1 Thoughtcast
- 1 The Ten Rings

TUTORS / RECURSION (4)

- 1 Goblin Welder
- 1 Goblin Engineer
- 1 Fabricate
- 1 Solve the Equation

INTERACTION (10)

- 1 An Offer You Can't Refuse
- 1 Galvanic Blast
- 1 Into the Flood Maw
- 1 Strix Serenade
- 1 Swan Song
- 1 Counterspell
- 1 Mystic Reflection
- 1 Chaos Warp
- 1 Deflecting Swat
- 1 Fierce Guardianship

BOARD WIPES (2)

- 1 Chandra's Ignition
- 1 Blasphemous Act

EQUIPMENT (VOLTRON PAYLOAD) (15)

- 1 Commander's Plate
- 1 Adaptive Omnitool
- 1 Buster Sword
- 1 Champion's Helm
- 1 Mithril Coat
- 1 Sword of Feast and Famine
- 1 Sword of Fire and Ice
- 1 The Reaver Cleaver
- 1 Mjölnir, Hammer of Thor
- 1 Genji Glove
- 1 Hexplate Wallbreaker
- 1 Aettir and Priwen
- 1 Embercleave
- 1 Ultima Weapon
- 1 Excalibur, Sword of Eden

ARTIFACT PAYOFFS / CREATURES (11)

- 1 Professional Face-Breaker
- 1 Simulacrum Synthesizer
- 1 Knuckles the Echidna
- 1 Phyrexian Metamorph
- 1 Roaming Throne
- 1 Iron Man, Titan of Innovation
- 1 Iron Man, Tony Stark
- 1 Extinguisher Battleship
- 1 Darksteel Forge
- 1 Krang, Utrom Warlord
- 1 Portal to Phyrexia

EXTRA COMBATS (5)

- 1 Great Train Heist
- 1 Aggravated Assault
- 1 Seize the Day
- 1 Overpowering Attack
- 1 Savage Beating

Build history — 7 substitutions made to finalize this list

IN		Adaptive Omnitoon {2} Equipped creature gets +1/+1 for each artifact you control. Whenever equipped creature attacks, look at the top six cards; you may reveal an artifact card and put it into your hand.	↔	Sword of Hearth and Home {3} Equipped creature gets +2/+2 and has protection from green and from white. Combat damage: blink a creature you own and fetch a basic.		OUT
Why: +1/+1 per artifact is routinely +10/+10 here, and the attack trigger digs six for an artifact INTO HAND — exactly where the free-drop trigger wants it. 4/5 field vs 1/5.			Bring back: Against heavy green/white creature decks where the protection matters more than the size.			

IN		Champion's Helm {3} Equipped creature gets +2/+2. As long as equipped creature is legendary, it has hexproof.	↔	Liquimetal Torque {2} {T}: Add {C}. {T}: Target nonland permanent becomes an artifact in addition to its other types until end of turn.		OUT
Why: The deck had ZERO hexproof; Commander's Plate covers only W/B/G, so blue and red removal walked straight through. Liquimetal Torque is 1/5 field, taps only for {C}, and its second ability is near-dead with no maindeck artifact removal. Talisman of Creativity was protected from this cut: 5/5 field and the only other rock making {U} or {R}.			Bring back: Alongside Vandalblast, for the turn-their-bomb-into-an-artifact line.			

IN		Chaos Warp {2}{R} The owner of target permanent shuffles it into their library, then reveals the top card. If it's a permanent card, they put it onto the battlefield.	↔	Reality Shift {1}{U} Exile target creature. Its controller manifests the top card of their library.		OUT
Why: The base had no clean answer to a resolved NONCREATURE permanent. Reality Shift also hands an opponent a 2/2 blocker, which is a real cost when your kill is a flier. 3/5 field vs 1/5.			Bring back: Never.			

IN		Iron Man, Tony Stark {3}{R}{R} Flying. Attacking creatures you control get +1/+0. Whenever you cast a red spell, create a 2/1 colorless Robot Hero artifact creature token with flying.	↔	Hulking Metamorph {9} Prototype {2}{U}{U} - 3/3. May enter as a copy of an artifact or creature you control.		OUT
Why: It is a Human HERO, so Roaming Throne naming Hero makes it the THIRD doubled trigger - two 2/1 flying artifact tokens per red spell, off 21 red spells. Each token is +1/+1 to the commander via Adaptive Omnitoon, plus metalcraft, affinity and artifact count. Hulking Metamorph was 1/5 field, the weakest card in the 100. Artifact creature out, artifact creature in - creature count stays 10.			Bring back: Only if Roaming Throne leaves the deck; without the Throne it is a 5-drop competing with the flip turn.			

IN



Roaming Throne {4}

Ward {2}. As this creature enters, choose a creature type. If a triggered ability of another creature you control of the chosen type triggers, it triggers an additional time.



Auton Soldier {4}{U}{U}

May enter as a copy of any creature on the battlefield, except it isn't legendary, is an artifact, and has myriad.



OUT

Why: Choose HERO. The back face is a Legendary Artifact Creature - Human Hero, so the combat trigger fires twice: two free artifacts a combat, both Equipment attached to the REAL commander. Also doubles Iron Man, Titan of Innovation (also a Human Hero). Auton Soldier tried the same job but per CR 201.5 the copy's trigger attaches gear to ITSELF, and commander damage only counts from your actual commander.

Bring back: Never.

IN



Ultima Weapon {7}

Whenever equipped creature attacks, destroy target creature an opponent controls. Equipped creature gets +7/+7. Equip {7}



Sword of the Animist {2}

Equipped creature gets +1/+1. Whenever equipped creature attacks, search your library for a basic land, put it onto the battlefield tapped.



OUT

Why: Cast {7} and equip {7} make it unplayable normally — which is why it belongs here: the commander deploys AND attaches it free. 5/5 becomes 12/12, and 24 with Mjolnir is lethal commander damage in one swing. Plus it kills a creature every attack, before blockers.

Bring back: Never. Sword of the Animist is a ramp sword in a deck that cheats artifacts in anyway.

IN



Volcanic Island land

Land - Island Mountain. ({T}: Add {U} or {R}.) No drawback: enters untapped, costs no life, and is still a fetch target.



Bloodstained Mire land

{T}, Pay 1 life, Sacrifice this land: Search your library for a Swamp or Mountain card, put it onto the battlefield, then shuffle.



OUT

Why: Three of the four fetches only had one live half and no payoff behind them - the deck runs zero shuffle effects (no Sensei's Top, no Brainstorm), fixing is easy in two colours, and thinning is noise. Their only real cost mattered: Aettir and Priwen sets the commander's base P/T to your LIFE TOTAL, and the deck already bleeds from Ancient Tomb, Shivan Reef, Talisman and The One Ring. Fetches are the budget-agnostic way to smooth a manabase; remove the money constraint and you just play the best duals. Also swapped Wooded Foothills for Riverpyre Verge and Misty Rainforest for Sulfur Falls. Also added Scorched Geyser (enters tapped only if you control fewer than two basics - trivially met) over a basic Island. Sources went U21/R20 to U23/R22 with zero extra life paid.

Bring back: Never. Scalding Tarn STAYS - Volcanic Island is Island Mountain typed, so the Tarn is effectively a second Volcanic Island for 1 life, and singleton means that's the only way to run a second copy of your best dual.

Sideboard — what to bring in, and when



Darksteel Plate {3}

Bring in: Heavy damage-based sweepers. Second indestructible source; makes your own Blasphemous Act fully one-sided. Displaces Champion's Helm.



Lightning Greaves {2}

Bring in: NEVER. Grants shroud — you could no longer equip anything else to your own commander. Same for Whispersilk Cloak.



Master Transmuter {3}{U}

Bring in: STRICT BRACKET 3: swap in for Aggravated Assault. Assault goes infinite with BOTH The Reaper Cleaver and Sword of Feast and Famine, which the commander attaches free.



Padeem, Consul of Innovation {3}{U}

Bring in: Targeted-removal-heavy pods. Hexproof for ALL your artifacts — the back face is an Artifact Creature, so it covers the commander. Costs a creature slot, which makes your own sweepers slightly worse. Displaces Insight Engine.



Rogue's Passage land

Bring in: Fliers and reach at the table. {4},{T} for unblockable is the guaranteed connection when trample isn't enough. Displaces Fomori Vault.



Sword of Fire and Ice {3}

Bring in: MAINDECKED — pilot note, not a sideboard card. Pro-red unattaches Mjolnir, The Reaver Cleaver and Embercleave (CR 702.16d), so they are mutually exclusive ON THE COMMANDER. Decline the combat trigger rather than deploying SoFI while Mjolnir is attached. Best home is Knuckles: double strike fires its trigger twice.



Urza, Lord High Artificer {2}{U}{U}

Bring in: Power upgrade that is NOT a Game Changer, so it stays bracket 3. Taps your artifacts for {U}, so it partly replaces a rock. Displaces Cursed Mirror.



Vandalblast {R}

Bring in: Another artifact deck in the pod. Overload {4}{R} is a one-sided wipe in the mirror. Displaces Galvanic Blast.



Vision of Love {1}{R}

Bring in: More instant-speed draw. Sacrifice an artifact (usually a Treasure) or discard, draw two. Lost to Insight Engine because that one's charge counters accumulate - {2} for 1 card, then 2, then 3. Displaces Big Score.

IRON MAN — PILOT NOTES

The deck in one line

It cheats artifacts into play instead of casting them. Everything else follows from that: the low creature count (so your own sweepers are near one-sided), the doubled tutor count (find the *specific* piece), the low cost reduction (your nine-drops arrive free), and the seven extra-combat effects (one huge commander swinging repeatedly is the kill).

The two routes to a 5/5, and when to pick each

Your commander is a **modal** DFC (CR 712.11b), so you choose a face every time you cast it from the command zone. Both routes cost 6 mana total the first time:

Route	Cost	When
Tony Stark first — cast 1 on turn 2, dig with 1, each turn, transform later for 4	2 now + 6 later	Default. The dig engine is most of your early card advantage, and nobody spends removal on a 1/3.
Straight to the 5/5 — cast The Invincible Iron Man for 4	6	You're behind, you already have Equipment in hand, or you need a clock now. Flying + haste means it attacks immediately.

Transforming is **sorcery-speed only**. Casting the back face from the command zone is not, but it's still a creature spell.

After it dies: recast the back face directly for 4 + 2 tax = 8 mana. Don't recast the 1/3 and re-flip (10 mana over two turns) unless you're mana-screwed and want the dig back.

The single most important habit: keep Equipment in your hand

The trigger reads "*you may put an artifact card **from your hand** onto the battlefield. If it's an Equipment, attach it to The Invincible Iron Man.*" That's a free drop **and** a free equip.

Equipment already on the battlefield gets neither — you pay full equip costs. And when the commander dies, everything attached falls off and stays there unattached (CR 704.5n).

So: **don't cast your gear**. Cast rocks, draw and interaction; let the trigger deploy the swords. Excalibur (12), Ultima Weapon (7, **equip** 7) and Aettir and Priwen (6) should essentially never be hard-cast.

Roaming Throne doubles the whole plan

Choose **Hero**. The Invincible Iron Man is a *Legendary Artifact Creature — Human Hero*, so the combat trigger fires **twice** — two free artifacts a combat, both Equipment auto-attached.

Mjöltnir + Ultima Weapon in one turn is 12 power doubled = **24, lethal**.

It doubles **three** Hero triggers at once:

1. The commander's combat trigger → two free artifacts, both Equipment attached
2. **Iron Man, Titan of Innovation** → two Treasures and two tutors per attack
3. **Iron Man, Tony Stark** → two 2/1 flying artifact tokens per red spell (21 red spells)

Those tokens are **artifacts**, so each one is +1/+1 to the commander through Adaptive Omnitool, and with Krang out they're indestructible hasty tramlers.

Kill math

Base is a **5/5 flier with haste**. You need **21 commander damage**.

Package	Power	Damage	Turns
Mjöltnir alone (doubles all damage)	5	10/hit	3 combats
Mjöltnir + Ultima Weapon	12	24	1 hit
Mjöltnir + Excalibur	15	30	1 hit
Mjöltnir + Genji Glove (double strike + extra combat)	5	20 + 20	1 turn
Aettir and Priwen (base P/T = life total)	~40	40 (80 with Mjöltnir)	1 hit

Mjöltnir, Hammer of Thor is the linchpin. Equip *worthy* 1 needs a legendary non-Villain that's red and/or white — the back face is a legendary red Hero, so it qualifies.

Chandra's Ignition is the second kill. "*Each **other** creature and each opponent*" — it doesn't hit Iron Man, and **Mjöltnir doubles it**. A 15-power commander deals 30 to every opponent and clears the table's creatures.

Getting through blockers

Flying is not enough on its own. In order of reliability:

1. **Trample** (The Reaver Cleaver, Embercleave). Beats every blocker including colorless ones.

Per **CR 702.19b** you assign trample damage ignoring "*any abilities or effects that might change the amount of damage that's actually dealt*" — so a 12/12 trampler chump-blocked by a 2/2 assigns 2 to the blocker and 10 to the player, and **then** Mjölñir doubles it: **20 commander damage through the chump block**.

1. **Ultima Weapon** — destroys a creature when you *attack*, before blockers are declared. Kill

the best blocker pre-emptively.

1. **Commander's Plate** — pro-W/B/G plus innate flying leaves only U/R fliers and colorless

creatures able to block.

Note that **protection does not stop colorless blockers**, which is why trample outranks it in an artifact format full of Constructs, Thopters and Servos.

Sequencing traps

- **Blasphemous Act kills your own commander**. Only fire it with Mithril Coat attached, Darksteel

Forge out, or when you're rebuilding anyway.

- **Extinguisher Battleship is your free, near-one-sided wipe**. 4 damage doesn't kill a 5/5

commander. Hold it for when the table has blockers, and remember the ETB also destroys a noncreature permanent.

- **Never attach a shroud source**. Nothing in the deck grants it, but if one arrives via Phyrexian

Metamorph or a Mycosynth Gardens copy, keep it off Iron Man — you'd lock yourself out of equipping. The free combat attach still works through shroud (CR 701.3a, attaching doesn't target), but nothing else does.

- **Sword of Fire and Ice and Mjölñir cannot share the commander**. SoFI grants pro-red, and

Mjölñir , The Reaver Cleaver  and Embercleave  are all red cards — they'd fall off as a state-based action (CR 702.16d). Pick a lane: Mjölñir + Ultima Weapon is the fast kill; Commander's Plate + SoFI is the near-unblockable grind. **The trap:** the combat trigger's attach is *not* optional, so with Mjölñir on, **decline the trigger** rather than deploying SoFI with it. Better yet, hard-cast SoFI onto **Knuckles** — double strike fires its trigger twice for 4 damage and 2 cards. Commander's Plate is always safe; it only grants protection from colours *outside* your commander's identity.

- **Extra-combat spells want the gear on first**. Savage Beating, Seize the Day, Overpowering

Attack, Great Train Heist and Aggravated Assault all multiply what's already attached.

- **Aggravated Assault goes infinite** with The Reaver Cleaver (damage → Treasures → pay

) or Sword of Feast and Famine (damage → untap all lands → pay again). Know that before you sit down at a strict bracket-3 table.

- **Start Insight Engine early**. Its counters accumulate, so the third activation draws 3 for

. It's slow the turn you cast it and excellent two turns later — deploy it before you need it.

- **Otawara and Sink into Stupor are lands you can cast**. Count them as lands when keeping a hand,

but they're outs to a problem permanent.

Mulligan guide

Keep anything with 2+ lands, a rock or Sol Ring, and either Tony Stark on curve or a way to dig. You're mulliganing for **mana**, not threats — the commander is the threat.

Ship hands with 3+ cards at MV 6 and no ramp. The fat is free later, but only if you survive to flip.

Do **not** keep a hand full of Equipment and no lands. Equipment is the payoff, not the engine.

FIELD ANALYSIS — 7 SAMPLE IRON MAN DECKS

Measured 2026-08-07 from the links in `~/Desktop/iron-man decks`. Raw lists archived in `../samples/`. Method: pulled each list via API, priced every card through the local Scryfall tool, then tiered by price **before** counting anything — so a card that appears often only because it is cheap can't masquerade as consensus.

The tiers

Deck	Price	Commander	Tier
I love you 3000	\$1,369	Tony Stark	Optimized
Tin Man	\$899	Tony Stark	Optimized
Tico MTG	\$810	Tony Stark	Optimized
Iron Man	\$697	Tony Stark	Optimized
One Punch	\$645	Tony Stark	Optimized
\$100 Budget Voltron	\$128	Tony Stark	Budget — do not count as field signal
\$100 Iron Man B2 (Archidekt)	\$163	Iron Man, Titan of Innovation	Different commander — excluded

The Archidekt list is a **different commander entirely**. So is the `~/Desktop/iron-man-suggestions.txt` file — every card in it is justified by Titan of Innovation's attack trigger ("since ironman taps the artifact", "when you sack it to ironman", "draw a card when you make a treasure"). Neither describes Tony Stark. Both excluded from field counts; the suggestions file is still mined for individually-good cards in `decisions.md`.

Field signal is therefore **n=5**, all optimized, all Tony Stark.

The finding that changed the build

Deck	Price	Equipment	Artifacts MV6+
I love you 3000	\$1,369	14	10
Tin Man	\$899	19	8
Tico MTG	\$810	13	10
Iron Man	\$697	12	5
One Punch	\$645	14	10
\$100 Budget Voltron	\$128	22	3

Every unconstrained list is hybrid — 12–19 Equipment *and* 5–10 fat artifacts. The budget deck is the only one that looks like pure Equipment voltron, and that is a price artifact, not a design choice: Darksteel Forge (\$46), Portal to Phyrexia (\$45) and Blightsteel Colossus (\$39) are exactly the cards a \$100 cap removes, and cheap Equipment is what backfills the slots.

Reading "most decks run lots of Equipment and few fatties" off the whole sample would have inverted the actual consensus. This is the trap the tiering exists to catch.

Quality metrics (optimized tier only)

	I♥3000	Tin Man	Tico	Iron Man	One Punch
Counterspells	5	3	6	4	3
Tutors	8	4	3	3	4
Game Changers	3	0	1	1	0
Avg MV (nonland)	3.59	3.31	3.58	3.26	3.62
Lands	37	38	34	38	37

I love you 3000 wins on substance, not just price — most tutors, near-most counterspells, best manabase (Ancient Tomb, four fetches, Steam Vents, Mycosynth Gardens), and the only list with a coherent extra-combat package rather than a pile of good cards. It is the chosen base.

Its 3 Game Changers (Ancient Tomb, Fierce Guardianship, The One Ring) put it **exactly at the bracket 3 cap**, so no Game Changer can be added without going to bracket 4.

The role table — the analysis that governed the build

Counted across the five optimized decks. This is the measurement that stopped a nine-card swap package from going in.

Role	lv3000	Tin Man	Tico	Iron Man	One Punch	Field avg
Lands	37	38	34	38	37	36.8
Mana rocks	8	5	6	7	9	7.0
Cost reduction	6	12	11	11	6	9.2
Draw	10	9	14	12	10	11.0
Tutors	8	4	3	3	4	4.4
Counterspells	5	3	6	4	3	4.2
Removal	4	4	3	2	2	3.0
Equipment	14	19	13	12	14	14.4
Big artifacts 6+	10	8	10	5	10	8.6
Extra combats	7	1	1	1	3	2.6
Creatures	10	18	23	25	17	18.6

The base deck's four biggest deviations are one decision, not four flaws. Most tutors, most extra combats, fewest creatures, lowest cost reduction — all follow from *this deck cheats artifacts into play instead of casting them*. It doesn't need cost reduction because its nine-drops arrive free; it runs double the tutors because finding the specific piece matters more than having cheap ones; and it stays creature-light **so its own Blasphemous Act and Extinguisher Battleship are close to one-sided**.

Every other deck in the sample is a *cast-artifacts* deck. This is a *cheat-artifacts* deck — the outlier because it's the most committed.

Consequence for the build: a package adding Shuri, Emry, Jhoira, Padeem, Foundry Inspector and Etherium Sculptor would have moved creatures 10 → 14 and cost reduction 6 → 9. That isn't an upgrade; it converts this list into the *average* deck in the sample and makes its own sweepers worse. It was dropped. **Nine changes were accepted in total** — six inside the Equipment, interaction, creature and draw slots, plus a three-card manabase pass. Creature count (10), artifact count (41), land count (37) and Game Changer count (3/3) are all unchanged from the base.

Consensus staples (4+/5) present in the final list

Academy Ruins · Adaptive Omnitool · An Offer You Can't Refuse · Arcane Signet · Archway of Innovation · Armor Wars · Blasphemous Act · Buster Sword · Cascade Bluffs · Command Tower · Commander's Plate · Counterspell · Darksteel Citadel · Darksteel Forge · Excalibur, Sword of Eden · Fabricate · Genji Glove · Great Furnace · Inventors' Fair · Krang, Utrom Warlord · Mjölnir, Hammer of Thor · Seat of the Synod · Shivan Reef · Silverbluff Bridge · Simulacrum Synthesizer · Sol Ring · Steam Vents · Stormcarved Coast · Sulfur Falls · Swan Song · Talisman of Creativity · The Reaver Cleaver · Thran Dynamo · Training Center · Uthros, Titanic Godcore

Consensus staples deliberately NOT run

These lost on the role table, not on card quality — the deck has no hole for them.

- **Shuri** (4/5), **Emry** (4/5), **Jhoira** (4/5), **Foundry Inspector** (3/5), **Etherium

Sculptor **(3/5)**, Ironheart** (3/5) — all cost reduction or cheap creatures. Adding them breaks the low-creature / one-sided-sweeper coherence described above.

- **Swiftfoot Boots** (4/5) — hexproof is covered by Champion's Helm; a second source is

redundant.

- **Lightning Greaves** (3/5) — grants *shroud*, which stops you equipping your own commander.
- **Vandalblast** (3/5), **Reliquary Tower** (3/5), **Padeem** (3/5), **Cyberdrive Awakener**

(3/5), **Ultron** (3/5), **Iron Man, Master of Machines** (3/5), **Iron Man, Bleeding Edge** (3/5), **Enthusiastic Mechanaut** (3/5) — reasonable, lost slot competition. The closest sit in `../SIDEBOARD.md`.

IRON MAN — DECISION LOG

Append-only. Newest entries at the bottom. Record the **grounds**, not just the verdict.

2026-08-07 — Commander: Tony Stark // The Invincible Iron Man

Grounds: Nine Iron Man legends are Commander-legal; three are Izzet. The sample folder is split — 6 of 7 decks and all 7 YouTube videos build **Tony Stark**, while the Archidekt list and `~/Desktop/iron-man-suggestions.txt` are for **Iron Man, Titan of Innovation**. "Voltron" only describes Tony Stark, whose back face attaches Equipment from hand for free every combat.

Rejected: *Iron Man, Titan of Innovation* as commander — an artifact-chain toolbox that tutors artifacts in **tapped** (which is why the suggestions file wants Amulet of Vigor). Kept in the 99. *Iron Man, Master of Machines* — a real voltron threat at 29¢ needing zero Equipment, but 1/4 base is fragile and no sample runs it as commander.

2026-08-07 — Base: "I love you 3000", improved rather than averaged

Grounds: User's call, and the role table supports it. Measured across the five optimized sample decks (see `field-analysis.md`), this list leads on tutors (8 vs a field average of 4.4), is near-top on counterspells (5), has the best manabase, and is the only one with a deliberate extra-combat package (7 effects vs a field average of 2.6).

The key structural finding, and the one that governs every later decision:

The base deck's four biggest deviations from the field — **most tutors, most extra combats, fewest creatures (10 vs 18.6), lowest cost reduction (6 vs 9.2)** — are not four flaws. They are one decision applied consistently: **this deck cheats artifacts into play instead of casting them.**

It doesn't need cost reduction because its nine-drops arrive free. It runs double the tutors because finding the *specific* piece matters more than having cheap ones. It stays creature-light **so that Blasphemous Act and Extinguisher Battleship are close to one-sided**. Every other deck in the sample is a *cast-artifacts* deck; this is a *cheat-artifacts* deck.

Changes accepted: **six** (five below, plus one later reversal recorded at the bottom of this file). Every one sits inside the Equipment, interaction, creature or draw slots as a like-for-like trade. **Creature count (10), artifact count, land count (37) and Game Changer count (3/3) are all unchanged from the base** — that constraint is what kept the cheat-artifacts identity intact.

2026-08-07 — RULES: the commander is a *modal* DFC, so removal is cheaper than it looks

Grounds: Scryfall layout: `modal_dfc`. **CR 712.11b** — "*A player casting a modal double-faced card... chooses which face they are casting before putting it onto the stack.*"

After the commander dies or is exiled and goes to the command zone (**CR 903.9a**), recast **The Invincible Iron Man directly** for `4`   + tax (**CR 903.8**) — 8 mana the first time. You never have to recast the `1`  front face and pay the 6-mana sorcery-speed flip again.

What it does cost: **CR 704.5n** — Equipment attached to an illegal permanent "*becomes unattached... It remains on the battlefield.*" The gear survives but falls off, and the combat trigger only attaches artifacts **from your hand**, so re-suiting off the board costs full equip prices.

Changes: Hold Equipment in hand. The trigger is free; equip costs are not.

2026-08-07 — The first five accepted changes

OUT	IN	Grounds
Sword of the Animist	Ultima Weapon	7 cast, equip 7 — unplayable in a normal deck, which is exactly why it belongs here: the trigger deploys <i>and</i> attaches it free. 5/5 → 12/12, and 24 with Mjöllnir = lethal commander damage in one swing. Plus it destroys a creature every attack, which answers the chump-blocker problem. Sword of the Animist was the weakest Equipment — a ramp sword in a deck that cheats things in anyway.
Reality Shift	Chaos Warp	The base had no clean answer to a resolved noncreature permanent. Reality Shift also <i>"manifests the top card of their library"</i> — it hands an opponent a 2/2 blocker, which is a real cost when your kill is a flier. Reality Shift was 1/5 in the field.
Auton Soldier	Roaming Throne	Both try to double the commander's trigger; only one works. Choose Hero (the back face is a <i>Legendary Artifact Creature — Human Hero</i>) and the beginning-of-combat trigger fires twice — two free artifacts a combat, both Equipment attached to the real commander. It also doubles Iron Man, Titan of Innovation, which is likewise a Human Hero. Artifact creature out, artifact creature in, so nothing structural moves.
Sword of Hearth and Home	Adaptive Omnitool	Both 3 Equipment. +1/+1 per artifact is routinely +10/+10 here, and the attack trigger digs six for an artifact into hand — precisely where the free-drop trigger wants it. 4/5 field vs 1/5.
Liquimetal Torque	Champion's Helm	The base had zero hexproof ; Commander's Plate covers W/B/G, so blue and red removal walked straight through. Liquimetal Torque was 1/5 in the field, taps only for ⬠, and its second ability (<i>"target nonland permanent becomes an artifact"</i>) is near-dead here — nothing in the maindeck punishes artifacts. Talisman of Creativity was explicitly protected from this cut : 5/5 field, and it's the only other rock producing ♀ or ♂ for a 4 ♀♂ commander off 19 blue / 17 red sources.

2026-08-07 — Sword of Fire and Ice: argued twice, KEPT on the user's call

Note the sequence. SoFI was first proposed as a cut, then reinstated. Final state: **it stays**, and Champion's Helm came in over Liquimetal Torque instead. Equipment went 14 → 15.

The rules constraint is real and permanent, so the pilot needs to know it — see the entry below. What changed is the *cost* of keeping it: paying a marginal mana rock instead of the hexproof slot.

2026-08-07 — The SoFI / Mjöllnir constraint (still applies, since SoFI is maindecked)

CR 702.16d — *"A permanent with protection can't be equipped by Equipment that have the stated quality. Such Equipment become unattached from that permanent as a state-based action."* SoFI grants pro-**red**; Mjöllnir 3 ♂, The Reaver Cleaver 2 ♂ and Embercleave 4 ♂♂ are all red cards, so all three fall off.

The counter-argument (user's, and it was good): SoFI + Commander's Plate gives protection from **all five colours** — both are colourless Equipment, so they coexist — and the point isn't dodging removal, it's that **the commander can never be blocked**, guaranteeing commander damage.

What settled it: protection doesn't stop **colorless** blockers, and this is an artifact format full of Constructs, Thopters, Servos and Eldrazi. Pro-all-colours still gets chump-blocked. **Trample does not.** And per **CR 702.19b**, when assigning trample damage you ignore *"any abilities or effects that might change the amount of damage that's actually dealt"* — so a 12/12 trampler chump-blocked by a 2/2 assigns 2 to the blocker and 10 to the player, and **then** Mjöllnir doubles: **20 commander damage straight through the chump block.**

Ranked against the actual goal of "always connect": trample (already in the deck twice) > Ultima Weapon killing a blocker pre-blocks > Commander's Plate + innate flying > SoFI.

How to pilot it, now that both are maindecked. They are mutually exclusive **on the commander**, not in the deck:

- **Pick a lane on the draw.** Mjöllnir + Ultima Weapon/Excalibur is the fast kill (24–30 in one swing). Commander's Plate + SoFI is the grindy near-unblockable lane (10 power, ~3 connections).
- **The trap is the mandatory attach.** The combat trigger reads **"you may** put an artifact card from your hand onto the battlefield. If it's an Equipment, **attach it**" — the "may" governs putting it onto the battlefield, but the attach is not optional. So with Mjöllnir already on, **decline the trigger** rather than deploying SoFI with it.
- **SoFI is excellent on a second creature.** Hard-cast it and equip 2 to Knuckles the Echidna —

double strike means the trigger fires twice, for 4 damage and 2 cards. Professional Face-Breaker and Roaming Throne are fine holders too. Keeping it out of the commander's lane costs you nothing.

2026-08-07 — Corrections. Three proposals were withdrawn; all three were my errors.

Logged because the reasoning failure is more transferable than the card choices.

1. Proposed cutting Hexplate Wallbreaker. Wrong. I verified that For Mirrodin! (**CR 702.163a**) moves the Equipment onto a fresh 2/2 token and stopped there — never reading what the Equipment *does* once it's on the token. *"Untap each attacking creature... there is an additional combat phase"* are both **global**. The commander gets the extra combat regardless of who holds the sword. It's a self-contained extra-combat engine that never competes for an

Equipment slot. (The rule is still worth knowing for **Kaldra Compleat** and **Nettlecyst**, whose bonuses *are* all on the equipped creature — those genuinely don't suit up the commander.)

2. Proposed cutting Extinguisher Battleship as a bad Spacecraft. Wrong — it's a free wipe. I read the Station text, judged stationing awkward in a creature-light deck, and never priced the ETB alone: *destroy target noncreature permanent and 4 damage to each creature*, for **zero mana** off the trigger. Critically, **4 damage does not kill a 5/5 commander**, so it is asymmetric in your favour by default — better than Blasphemous Act, which kills your own commander. And the "it kills my small creatures" objection was weak because **you choose when to deploy it**.

3. Proposed cutting Knuckles the Echidna as filler. Wrong — it's part of a package. Measured: **6 Treasure makers** (Knuckles, Professional Face-Breaker, The Reaver Cleaver, Iron Man Titan of Innovation, Great Train Heist, Treasure Vault) feeding **10 artifact-count payoffs** (Arc Reactor, Armor Wars, Fomori Vault, Galvanic Blast, Inventors' Fair, One with the Machine, Simulacrum Synthesizer, Thoughtcast, Urza's Saga, Uthros). Treasures here aren't just ramp — they're artifact count, which a third of the deck cares about.

The common root cause: I compared cards head-to-head before counting roles, which is backwards and is exactly what `deck-brain SKILL.md §2.1` forbids. Doing the role table *first* showed the deck had none of the holes my swaps were filling, and that a nine-card package would have quietly converted a committed cheat-artifacts deck into the average cast-artifacts deck in the sample.

2026-08-07 — Kept, despite looking cuttable

- **Iron Man, Titan of Innovation** — the sacrifice is **optional**, and the normal line feeds it

the Treasure it just made (MV 0 → tutor an MV 1 artifact), so nothing is really lost. Recursion is thin but real: Goblin Welder, Goblin Engineer (returns $MV \leq 3$ artifacts to the battlefield), Academy Ruins. And it's a **Human Hero**, so Roaming Throne doubles its attack trigger.

- **Aggravated Assault** — kept, but know what it is. It goes infinite with **two** different

Equipment the commander attaches for free: The Reaver Cleaver (damage → Treasures → pay 3 ) and Sword of Feast and Famine (damage → untap all lands → pay again). WotC permits bracket 3 decks where "*the long game could end with one being deployed*", and at 7 extra-combat effects the card is core to the design rather than bolted on — but with two redundant lines this list is honestly **bracket 3.5**. Cutting Aggravated Assault alone brings it back down.

- **Blasphemous Act** — kills the commander unless indestructible. Sequence it *after* Mithril Coat

or Darksteel Forge. 5/5 field.

- **Chandra's Ignition** — "*each **other** creature*", so it spares Iron Man, and ****Mjölñir**

doubles it^{**}: a 15-power commander deals 30 to every opponent. Second table-killer, not a wipe.

2026-08-07 — Rejected, with grounds

- **Gauntlet of Power** — "*Creatures of the chosen color get +1/+1*" has **no "you control"**, and

the mana clause is "*whenever a **basic land**... **its controller** adds*". Both symmetric, and the deck runs only **10 basics**. Caged Sun is strictly better on both clauses and still doesn't earn a slot, because the payload is colourless Equipment and the mana problem is reaching 6.

- **Mana Geyser** — a sorcery, so on your main phase opponents' lands are mostly untapped. And late

game the commander deploys your expensive cards free, so a burst of red has nothing to buy.

- **Machine God's Effigy** — the obvious line (copy the commander) is blanked by the legend rule.
- **Worldwalker Helm** — needs a token *engine*; the deck has loose sources, not an engine.
- **Trophy Mage** — 8 live targets, better than expected, but Fabricate costs the same and finds

any artifact.

- **Panharmonicon** — does **not** double the commander's trigger. It only doubles triggers caused

by something *entering*; the commander's is a beginning-of-combat trigger.

- **Lightning Greaves / Whispersilk Cloak** — grant **shroud**, which stops *you* equipping and

targeting your own commander. Note the free combat attach still works through shroud, because **CR 701.3a** makes attaching a keyword action that doesn't target — but nothing else does.

- **Doctor Doom** (all printings) — black or Grixis, outside a UR identity.

2026-08-07 — Iron Man, Tony Stark IN, after Roaming Throne changed its value

Reversal, and the grounds for it. It was passed earlier as "a 5-drop competing with the flip turn, and a go-wide engine in a deck that wins with one big flier." That evaluation was made **before Roaming Throne was in the list**, and never revisited afterwards — exactly the mistake `SKILL.md §1.1b` warns about: a verdict is a function of the deck around it, and the deck changed.

What changed: it is a *Legendary Artifact Creature* — **Human Hero**, so Roaming Throne naming **Hero** makes it the **third** doubled trigger, alongside the commander's beginning-of-combat trigger and Iron Man, Titan of Innovation's attack trigger. "*Whenever you cast a red spell, create a 2/1 colorless Robot*

Hero artifact creature token with flying" becomes **two** tokens per red spell, off 21 red spells.

The tokens compound rather than just sitting there: each is an **artifact**, so it's +1/+1 to the commander through Adaptive Omnitool, plus metalcraft for Galvanic Blast, affinity for Thoughtcast, and count for Armor Wars. With Krang out they're indestructible hasty trampers. Its anthem also gives the commander +1/+0, which Mjölñir turns into +2 damage.

OUT: Hulking Metamorph — 1/5 field, the weakest card in the 100. 9 (or prototype 2 for a 3/3) to copy an artifact or creature you already control. Artifact creature out, artifact creature in, so **creature count stays 10** and artifact count is unchanged.

Credit where due: the user spotted the Hero typing. I had checked Titan of Innovation's type line when Roaming Throne came up and never re-checked this one, because it was already cut.

2026-08-07 — Vision of Love proposed, then REVERTED. Insight Engine stays.

Proposed: Vision of Love 1 instant — "You may sacrifice an artifact or discard a card. If you do, draw two cards" — over Insight Engine, on the grounds that Insight Engine is 1/5 field and slow, while the deck has 6 Treasure makers to feed the sacrifice.

Reverted on the user's call, and the grounds are better than mine. Insight Engine's counters **accumulate**: "2, ♠: Put a charge counter on this artifact, then draw a card for each charge counter on it." So it's 2 → 1 card, 2 → 2 cards, 2 → 3 cards. From the third activation on it out-draws a one-shot Vision of Love **every turn**, and it keeps doing it.

I weighted "1/5 field signal" and "slow first activation" and under-weighted **repeatable**. In a deck with 8 mana rocks, 37 lands and a plan that wants a stocked hand every combat, an escalating engine beats a one-shot. It's also an artifact, so it feeds the 10 artifact-count payoffs, which a sorcery-speed instant never does.

Transferable form: compare a one-shot against a repeatable engine at the **turn count the deck actually reaches**, not at first activation. Insight Engine loses turn one and wins from turn three onward.

Vision of Love stays available — it's a fine card at 1 and the Treasure synergy is real. It just doesn't beat this particular slot.

2026-08-07 — Manabase: three fetches out, three real duals in

The question that started it: why run fetches at all, and why ones whose other half is off-colour?

Why they worked: the deck has three duals typed Land — Island Mountain (Steam Vents, Thundering Falls, Turbulent Springs) plus 10 basics — 13 targets. A fetch only needs **one** live half, so Bloodstained Mire and Wooded Foothills (Mountain) and Misty Rainforest (Island) all fetch an on-colour dual or basic. The off-colour half is dead text, not a mistake.

Why they still lost their slots. The four standard reasons to run a fetch:

1. *Fixing across 3+ colours* — this deck is two colours.
2. *Shuffle payoffs* — Brainstorm, Sensei's Divining Top, Scroll Rack. The deck runs **none**.
3. *Thinning* — ~0.5% each. Noise.
4. *A land that hasn't decided what it is yet* — real, but small with 13 targets already available.

And the singleton argument ("a fetch is another copy of your best dual") is weak here: only **one** of the three targets — Steam Vents — enters untapped. The other two are usually tapped, so fetches 2–4 were "pay 1 life, get a worse basic."

The cost that actually mattered: Aettir and Priwen sets the commander's base P/T to your life total. The deck already bleeds from Ancient Tomb (2/tap), Steam Vents, Shivan Reef, Talisman of Creativity and The One Ring's escalating upkeep. Paying 3 more life for nearly nothing is a direct shrink to a win condition.

The real reason the base list ran them: fetches are the *budget-agnostic* way to smooth a manabase. Volcanic Island is Reserved List at ~\$400+. Remove the money constraint — which proxying does — and the fetch's whole advantage evaporates: you just play the best duals.

OUT	IN	Why
Bloodstained Mire	Volcanic Island	The best UR land ever printed. No drawback text at all — untapped, no life, no condition — and it's Island Mountain typed, so Scalding Tarn can still fetch it.
Wooded Foothills	Riverpyre Verge	Always enters untapped, always taps for 🍷 (7 double-red cards want this). Blue half needs an Island/Mountain — there are 14. 3/5 field.
Misty Rainforest	Sulfur Falls	Untapped if you control an Island or Mountain — 14 enablers. 31¢, 4/5 field , the one consensus staple previously skipped.

Scalding Tarn stays, and the reason is stronger than "both halves live": Volcanic Island is Land — Island Mountain, so the Tarn **fetches it**. That makes Scalding Tarn effectively a **second Volcanic Island for 1 life** — and singleton means a fetch is the only way to run a second copy of your best dual. Its best untapped target used to be Steam Vents at 2 more life (3 total); now it's 1 life for a no-drawback dual.

This is also why we don't add fetches *back*: #2 would get Steam Vents (3 life), #3 a tapped dual. Sharp diminishing returns. **One fetch is correct.**
Also added: Scorched Geyser over a basic Island. Of the eight **Island Mountain** duals legal in Izzet we now run five; the three we don't (Coastal Peak, Molten Tributary, Volatile Fjord) all enter tapped unconditionally. Scorched Geyser is the exception — "*enters tapped unless you control two or more basic lands*", trivially met at 9 basics. Cutting a basic **Island** rather than a Mountain because red is the tighter colour (7 double-red cards vs 1 double-blue).

Result: sources **U21/R20** → **U23/R22**, three fewer life paid, three fewer sacrifice steps. Land count unchanged at 37; basics 10 → 9.

Correction logged: the "U19 / R17" figure previously in pdf . json counted only lands that *directly* tap for a colour and ignored what the fetches could retrieve. The true pre-change numbers were U21/R20.